

1 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

Build a fair riddle

What we are practising

Edit clues for accuracy, specificity and ambiguity.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Compose and test the riddle aloud.

Before you begin

Choose a familiar object such as a map, key or clock.

Keep clues kind and about objects or ideas, not personal traits of real people.

Try it together

1. List three true properties of the chosen object.
2. Turn the properties into clues without using its name.
3. Ask a partner for possible answers and check each against every clue.
4. Revise any clue that accidentally excludes the intended answer or allows too many alternatives.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does your riddle reward reasoning or rely on an unfair hidden assumption?

Space to explore

2 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

The evidence editor

What we are practising

Distinguish evidence, exaggeration and unanswered questions.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Discuss the example aloud and dictate a revision.

Before you begin

Write this fictional report: Eight of ten children at one club chose drawing over chess today.

Use the fictional example; do not collect names or post claims about real children.

Try it together

1. Read the headline: All children dislike chess!
2. Underline words the report does not support.
3. Write a more accurate headline that includes the group or sample.
4. List two things you would need to know before making a broader claim.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does choosing drawing mean a child dislikes chess?

Space to explore

3 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

A poem with a hidden word

What we are practising

Write within a letter constraint while using sensory detail.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Dictate each line to a partner.

Before you begin

Write SUN vertically down the page, one letter per line.

There is no requirement to share personal feelings or experiences.

Try it together

1. Begin three lines with S, U and N, in that order.
2. Use at least one detail you could see, hear or feel.
3. Read the poem aloud and replace one vague word with a clearer image.
4. Ask a partner to find the hidden word and describe the mood.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does each line contribute to the poem as well as fitting its letter?

Space to explore

4 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

Keep the meaning, cut the words

What we are practising

Prioritize information and check that a summary remains accurate.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Compare two spoken versions instead of counting written words.

Before you begin

Write: The library will hold a free drawing session on Saturday at ten in the morning. Bring a pencil. Paper will be provided. The session lasts one hour.

All event details are fictional; do not treat the notice as an actual invitation.

Try it together

1. Mark the event, place, day, start time, duration, cost and item to bring.
2. Write a shorter notice preserving those details.
3. Ask a partner to answer the seven marked questions using only your version.
4. Restore any essential detail that disappeared.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Which words can disappear without changing what a reader needs to do?

Space to explore

5 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 20 minutes

Make a reasoned proposal

What we are practising

Connect a claim to reasons and respond respectfully to another view.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Present the proposal aloud with three brief notes.

Before you begin

Imagine a garden with room for one new feature: a reading bench or a play table.

Keep disagreements about the proposal and avoid personal criticism.

Try it together

1. Choose a feature and give two reasons linked to how people would use it.
2. State one reasonable concern about your choice.
3. Suggest a practical way to address that concern.
4. Ask a partner to argue for the other choice, then revise one part of your proposal.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What information would help the group decide between the options?

Space to explore

6 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

What does “only” limit?

What we are practising

Explain how the position of a limiting word changes meaning.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Compare “Only Maya borrowed the map” with “Maya borrowed only the map”. Which sentence says Maya borrowed nothing else?

Space to explore

7 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

Two meanings for the binoculars

What we are practising

Spot ambiguity and rewrite to select one meaning.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“I saw the visitor with binoculars.” Could the speaker be using binoculars, or could the visitor have them?
Rewrite to make the speaker’s use clear.

Space to explore

8 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

How certain is likely?

What we are practising

Distinguish a likely event from a guaranteed event.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A fictional forecast says, “Rain is likely tomorrow.” Does it guarantee rain or say rain is expected but not certain?

Space to explore

9 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

After does not always mean because

What we are practising

Separate time order from evidence of cause.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“The class put up a blue poster on Monday. On Tuesday attendance rose, so the poster caused the rise.”
What is missing from that argument?

Space to explore

10 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

A metaphor in the hallway

What we are practising

Interpret a metaphor from the surrounding description.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“At break time, the hallway was a river of students flowing toward the yard.” Is this a report of flooding or a description of movement? Explain.

Space to explore

11 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

Keep the list in the same form

What we are practising

Recognise parallel grammatical forms in a list.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Improve this list: "We enjoy reading, drawing and to build models." Which ending keeps the same form as reading and drawing?

Space to explore

12 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

A summary without an extra claim

What we are practising

Summarise stated information without adding an unsupported claim.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“The park added three benches in May. Visitor numbers were not recorded.” Which summary is accurate: “The park added seating” or “New benches doubled visits”?

Space to explore

13 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

A respectful request to a librarian

What we are practising

Choose tone and detail suited to an audience and purpose.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

You need a librarian to help locate a book. Which is more useful: “Find it!” or “Could you help me find a book called Sea Paths?” Explain.

Space to explore

14 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

Do the two accounts disagree?

What we are practising

Reconcile compatible details from two short accounts.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Account A says “The bus reached the school at eight.” Account B says “Pupils stepped off at five past eight.” Must one account be false?

Space to explore

15 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

A reply that addresses the reason

What we are practising

Distinguish a relevant counterargument from a personal criticism.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Amir says, “The club should start later because many pupils arrive late.” Which reply addresses his reason: “Your handwriting is messy” or “Our arrival log shows most pupils are ready before the current start”?

Space to explore

16 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

Understand “unless”

What we are practising

Interpret an exception in a conditional instruction.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“We will use the garden unless it rains.” In this stated plan, what happens if it rains?

Space to explore

17 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

A judgement and a checkable detail

What we are practising

Separate a subjective evaluation from a verifiable detail.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“The story has twelve chapters and is the most exciting book ever.” Which part can be checked simply by counting?

Space to explore

18 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

Choose the link between paragraphs

What we are practising

Select a transition that matches contrast rather than cause.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

One paragraph lists benefits of walking to school. The next discusses rainy-weather difficulties. Which opener fits better: “However” or “For this reason”?

Space to explore

19 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

What is promised, exactly?

What we are practising

Read a quantified statement without overgeneralising.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A notice says, "Some activities need paper." Does it say every activity needs paper, no activity needs paper, or at least one does?

Space to explore

20 / 20 | Ages 9-12 | 10 minutes

Choose the precise verb

What we are practising

Choose a specific verb supported by observable action.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult is available for unfamiliar vocabulary or checking a calculation; no personal information is needed.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

“The child moved across the room slowly and quietly so the baby would not wake.” Which verb is more precise than moved: tiptoed or sprinted?

Space to explore

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

1. Build a fair riddle

A little hint

For a map, you might mention labelled places and drawn routes rather than claiming all maps show rivers.

Answer / what to notice

Many riddles work; accept another answer if it fits every clue, then refine the wording.

Testing with a listener reveals meanings the writer may have overlooked.

Make it easier

Start with a picture and two direct clues.

Take it further

Write a version in each language, adapting wordplay so both remain solvable.

Another day, away from the screen

Make a three-riddle family booklet with explained answers on the back.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

2. The evidence editor

A little hint

The report measures one choice on one day in one club.

Answer / what to notice

A supported headline is: Eight of ten children at this club chose drawing today.

Preference in one setting does not prove dislike, and a small local group does not represent all children.

Make it easier

Choose between an accurate and an exaggerated headline.

Take it further

Write a balanced caption showing both the count and the limits of the report.

Another day, away from the screen

Invent a harmless survey result and exchange headline-editing challenges.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

3. A poem with a hidden word

A little hint

A first line might be Soft light warms the windowsill.

Answer / what to notice

Any three coherent lines with initial letters S, U, N meet the letter rule; rhyme is optional.

The initial letters create the hidden word, while specific images give the poem meaning.

Make it easier

Use one descriptive word per letter.

Take it further

Choose a five-letter word and sustain one theme across all five lines.

Another day, away from the screen

Make an illustrated page and read it to a willing listener.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

4. Keep the meaning, cut the words

A little hint

A compact phrase such as Saturday, 10-11 am preserves the start and duration.

Answer / what to notice

One version: Free library drawing session, Saturday 10-11 am. Bring a pencil; paper provided.

A good summary removes repetition while retaining facts needed to understand or act on the message.

Make it easier

Shorten only the first two sentences.

Take it further

Write a full notice and a very short reminder, explaining which context each needs.

Another day, away from the screen

Condense instructions from a familiar game while keeping every necessary rule.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

5. Make a reasoned proposal

A little hint

A useful reason describes a need, such as a place to rest, rather than only saying it is best.

Answer / what to notice

Either choice can be defended; a strong proposal has relevant reasons, acknowledges a concern and suggests a response.

Considering an objection can improve a proposal rather than simply weaken it.

Make it easier

Give one reason for each option before choosing.

Take it further

Set a fictional budget and compare how each option meets several needs.

Another day, away from the screen

Write a one-paragraph proposal for improving a pretend reading corner.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

6. What does “only” limit?

A little hint

Ask whether only limits the person or the thing borrowed.

Answer / what to notice

Maya borrowed only the map.

Only before the map limits the object. Only Maya limits who borrowed it and does not list everything she borrowed.

Make it easier

Replace only with “and nothing else” to test each meaning.

Take it further

Write two sentences where moving only changes what is limited.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

7. Two meanings for the binoculars

A little hint

Say explicitly who uses or holds the binoculars.

Answer / what to notice

Both readings are possible. "Using binoculars, I saw the visitor."

The attachment of with binoculars is unclear. Naming the user removes the uncertainty.

Make it easier

Act out the two possible scenes.

Take it further

Rewrite to show the visitor holding binoculars.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

8. How certain is likely?

A little hint

Likely is stronger than merely possible, but weaker than certain.

Answer / what to notice

Rain is expected, but not guaranteed.

Likely expresses an expectation with uncertainty. It does not carry the same meaning as definitely.

Make it easier

Compare “may rain”, “likely to rain” and “will definitely rain”.

Take it further

Rewrite the forecast to express only a possibility, then explain what changed.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

9. After does not always mean because

A little hint

Could other things have changed between the days?

Answer / what to notice

Evidence connecting the poster to the rise and checking other possible causes.

One event happening earlier does not by itself prove it caused the later event.

Make it easier

Suggest one other possible reason, such as fewer absences from travel.

Take it further

Describe a fair comparison that could help test the poster idea.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

10. A metaphor in the hallway

A little hint

What are the moving things in the sentence?

Answer / what to notice

A description of many students moving in the same general direction.

River and flowing borrow water imagery to describe a crowd; the sentence names students as the moving group.

Make it easier

Replace river of students with crowd of students.

Take it further

Write a literal version, then explain what imagery it loses.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

11. Keep the list in the same form

A little hint

Use an -ing form in the same list.

Answer / what to notice

Building models: “We enjoy reading, drawing and building models.”

Matching forms makes the three activities easier to follow as equal items in one list.

Make it easier

Compare drawing with to draw before editing.

Take it further

Rewrite the whole list using verbs instead.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

12. A summary without an extra claim

A little hint

Which version adds a number the passage never gives?

Answer / what to notice

The park added seating.

The text supports added benches but gives no visitor-count evidence for a doubling.

Make it easier

List exactly the two facts stated before choosing.

Take it further

Write a one-sentence summary that also mentions the missing visitor data.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

13. A respectful request to a librarian

A little hint

Consider both politeness and the information needed.

Answer / what to notice

The second: it asks respectfully and supplies the title.

A clear, courteous request helps the listener understand both the task and the book sought.

Make it easier

Identify what information is absent from “Find it!”

Take it further

Rewrite the request if you know the topic but not the title.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

14. Do the two accounts disagree?

A little hint

Arriving and getting off need not happen at the same moment.

Answer / what to notice

No. Both can be true if pupils got off five minutes after arrival.

The accounts describe different events; the times can fit one sequence.

Make it easier

Draw arrival first and getting off second.

Take it further

Change one account so there is a direct contradiction about the arrival time.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

15. A reply that addresses the reason

A little hint

A useful reply should discuss attendance or timing.

Answer / what to notice

The reply about the arrival log.

The log bears on the stated reason; handwriting does not. The data still need checking before deciding.

Make it easier

Ask what Amir's reason actually concerns.

Take it further

Suggest a relevant question about the arrival log's dates or coverage.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

16. Understand “unless”

A little hint

Unless means except if in this sentence.

Answer / what to notice

The garden plan does not go ahead as stated.

Rain is the exception to using the garden; the sentence does not specify an alternative place.

Make it easier

Restate it as “If it does not rain, we will use the garden.”

Take it further

Write an equivalent sentence using if.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

17. A judgement and a checkable detail

A little hint

Separate the chapter count from the judgement of excitement.

Answer / what to notice

The claim that it has twelve chapters.

Chapters can be counted. Most exciting depends on a reader's judgement and is not established by that count.

Make it easier

Label each half countable or opinion.

Take it further

Rewrite the opinion to make the speaker's viewpoint explicit.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

18. Choose the link between paragraphs

A little hint

The second paragraph presents a limitation, not a result of the benefits.

Answer / what to notice

However.

However signals a contrast or qualification; for this reason suggests a causal result that is not given.

Make it easier

Replace the transition with “there is also a difficulty”.

Take it further

Invent a next paragraph where “For this reason” would fit.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

19. What is promised, exactly?

A little hint

Some is less specific than all or none.

Answer / what to notice

At least one does; the notice does not establish that every activity does.

Some confirms the existence of paper-using activities. It does not tell us the exact count or justify all.

Make it easier

Try a possible library with two paper activities and three without.

Take it further

Write a clearer notice if exactly three activities need paper.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

20. Choose the precise verb

A little hint

Match both the speed and the quietness.

Answer / what to notice

Tiptoed.

Tiptoed suggests careful, quiet steps; sprinted suggests fast running and does not match the stated movement.

Make it easier

Compare the actions using hand movements.

Take it further

Write a new sentence where sprinted would be the precise choice.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.